

Jurgen Gaeremyn, member of the Digital Freedom Foundation, wrote in to say: “In June of this year, I offered to help launch Software Freedom Day (SFD) globally. I found your name when searching through the first years of Software Freedom Day, and your account was the oldest one (apart from the founders) I could find in my list. Back in 2005, you were writing for BytesForAll.”

Jurgen says that the SFD team and its supporters in different pockets of the globe are celebrating the 20th edition of Software Freedom Day this year. “Thanks for being one of the very first supporters of SFD, and two decades later still standing for open source software, open data and open culture!”

Seizing the opportunity, I sent across some queries. Here is an excerpt of the exchange.

FN: How has SFD grown or changed over the years (since I last knew it)?

JG: Actually, SFD started back in the time when every self-respecting computer magazine offered a CD with some freebies on it. Back then Matt Oquist decided that burning a CD with actual free software (contrary to the freebies or trial versions on those other CDs) could add much value. He teamed up with Henrik Omma and Phil Harper and they decided to promote this OpenCD project all over the world. Things moved quickly from there.

Software Freedom Day actually reached its peak in 2008, when it was celebrated in at least 563 registered locations all over the world.

In 2010, Frederic Muller took over the initiative and widened the project, reflecting emerging changes. Broadband internet connections were becoming commonplace, and focal points were added — hardware freedom (think of the first Arduino boards that came out around 2011), document freedom (and open standards), and education that was also being impacted more and more through software platforms.

On May 27, 2019, a tragic accident took the life of Patrick Sinz, one of the board members at that moment. This was a heavy blow for the other board members, who were a close team of friends. Then came the global pandemic and organising events in 2020 and 2021 was nearly impossible. Even last year, there clearly still was a lot of reluctance to organise big events.

So now, in 2023, the existing board decided to hand over the project to a new team of volunteers. We started the launch of the 2023 edition of Software Freedom Day in June this year.

For the coming years, we'll be looking at offering a more centralised and functional online platform where communities can share their content for Software Freedom Day. We'll also be reaching out to sponsors who will offer tools empowering teams to organise their own events. Combining physical events with online access to presentations and workshops might be the way to go.

Oh and don't get me started about AI and how open source will be important there too, or we're off for another hour or two...

FN: How have the celebrations for this year shaped up?

JG: Where the first era was mainly about handing out swag like physical CDs and stickers, today it's more about building the community and offering online tools that are privacy-respecting.

For example, what are the trade-offs for putting all your documents, photos and personal mails in corporate owned vaults? Are there options to have your private cloud? Explaining how offline tools like LibreOffice on your computer don't need an internet connection, or showing how to stream not only to the major platforms but also to decentralised content providers might become essential skills.

The Muse Group, for example, has a nice approach to music notation.

They have an open source application (Musescore) that is fully featured, and is free to download and modify. To make it commercially viable, they also have an online platform MuseScore.com, where they offer sheet music for download and online music courses. They are actually sponsoring Software Freedom Day this year, and the team writing the best Software Freedom song will be awarded a year of access to this service.

We have connected with some other sponsors too, to send out prizes to SFD teams who excel in a specific field.

FN: What are the challenges the organisers were faced with this year? Can the community help?

JG: Because we were a little late to the game, there wasn't a lot of build-up to this event. But we always need help from the open source community to make some noise about it, and also start up events locally.

Even if you don't arrange big events, you could meet up with a class group in the local library to showcase your favourite open source drawing tool. Or maybe there's a hackerspace in your area that would like to teach how to program home automation using open source tools. Even if you're on your own, prepare a recording or live stream that you put out. Plenty of ideas — it's just a matter of finding a few friends and starting something.

There are other small things that can be done too:

- Follow us on social media (we're on Mastodon, Facebook, Twitter and occasionally also on other platforms) and share.
- Put our interactive banner on your website.
- If you're a company using or producing open source software, reach out to us at info@digitalfreedomfoundation.org if you'd like to sponsor a team (or all teams) in upcoming editions of Software Freedom Day with your tool.